



AUGUST 17-23, 2026

SONG 90 Encourage One Another

How to Maintain Christian Friendships

“Clothe yourselves with the tender affections of compassion, kindness, humility, mildness, and patience.”—COL. 3:12.

FOCUS

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² The friendships we seek to cultivate with our brothers and sisters are not casual or superficial. Rather, they are meaningful and deep. We are part of a family of worshippers who love Jehovah and Jesus, and this love unites us. ([John 13:35](#)) But such Christian friendships do not just happen. They require effort. And like any friendship between imperfect people, these friendships can have their challenges.

3. Why can it be a challenge to maintain friendships?

³ Realistically, we may feel closer to some than to others. Why? We may share similar interests, or we may have compatible personalities. But we may find that maintaining Christian friendships with other brothers and sisters can be a challenge. At times, we may disagree with one another, and this can strain our bond of affection. Perhaps

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⁴ To strengthen Christian friendships, we should look for the good in others. Spending time with our brothers and sisters can remind us of their fine qualities. The apostle Paul had a desire to be with his brothers and sisters. He wrote to the Thessalonians: “We made every effort to see you in person.” ([1 Thess. 2:17](#)) Many find that there is nothing quite like having face-to-face conversations to make their friendships stronger. We have many opportunities to do that as we share in the ministry and attend meetings, assemblies, and conventions together. But we may find that simply associating with one another does not prevent problems that could threaten our friendships.

5. What can help us to preserve a friendship that is threatened? Illustrate. ([Colossians 3:12](#))

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⁶ *Why is it a challenge?* When disagreements arise, each person may be convinced that his viewpoint is correct. Imagine two brothers who disagree about the best way to organize an activity for their field service group. Each is certain that his way is best. Can you see the potential for their difference of opinion to escalate and threaten their relationship? They might allow pride to affect them. If the matter is not discussed and settled, they could start to feel resentful. As time passes, they could risk drifting further apart and eventually risk no longer being friends—all because of a minor matter.

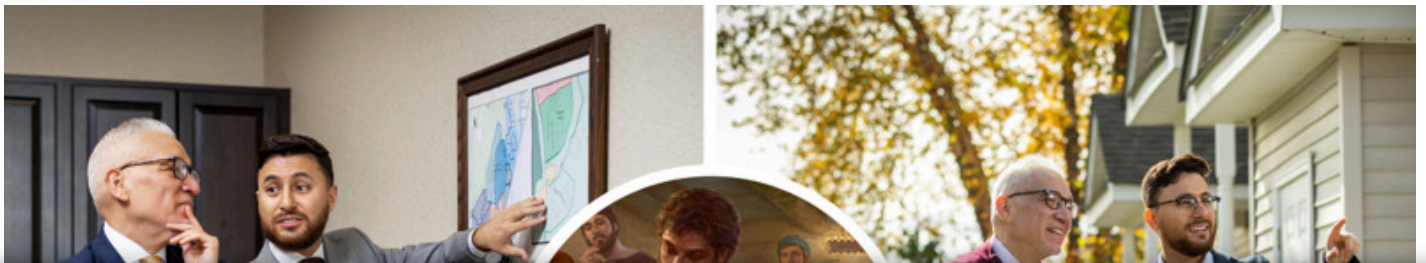
7. How did Jesus teach his disciples that humility was essential to overcoming disagreements?

⁷ *Learn from Jesus' humility.* He taught his disciples what was

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⁸ How can you maintain your friendships? Humility can help you to overlook minor disagreements and to forgive others freely. (**Read [Colossians 3:13](#)**.) With humility, you are more likely to preserve good relations by choosing not to react negatively. ([Ps. 4:4](#)) Even if unkind words have been said, remember that we all say things that we later regret. ([Eccl. 7:21, 22](#)) Ask yourself, ‘Is my insistence on being in the right worth more than our friendship?’ You could simply choose to yield to the other person’s opinion. Allow yourself to move on by neither dwelling on whatever you disagreed about nor bringing it up again.



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⁹ Humility can also help you when a disagreement persists. Do not argue to justify your viewpoint. **(Read [Proverbs 17:9](#); [1 Cor. 6:7](#))** You do well to set the goal of keeping your friend. Many have succeeded by kindly approaching the other person to settle the problem. ([Ps. 34:14](#)) You could say: ‘We’ve been friends for some time. Can we talk about what happened?’ Be prepared to admit your part in the disagreement, acknowledging any hurt feelings and then apologizing. And if your brother or sister also apologizes, accept it in a humble manner. ([Luke 17:3, 4](#)) Remember, your goal is, not to establish who was right and who was wrong, but to get past the disagreement and maintain the friendship.—[Prov. 18:24](#).

11

WHEN PERSONALITIES DIFFER

10. What can make it difficult to remain friends?

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11 *Learn from Jesus' patience.* He maintained friendships with those whose personalities differed from his. For example, the apostles James and John showed an ambitious spirit when they asked for prominent positions in the Kingdom. ([Mark 10:35-37](#)) In contrast, Jesus had humbly left behind his elevated heavenly position and privileges to come to earth. ([Phil. 2:5-8](#)) Think of how different their attitudes were. Still, Jesus was patient with James and John and with others.

12. What helped Jesus to be patient with his friends?

12 Jesus was realistic in what he expected of his friends. He knew that James and John's ambitious request reflected the competitive spirit of many of the disciples. ([Mark 9:34](#)) Jesus had grown up in the same religious environment that they had. It placed a high value on prominence and position, so he could understand their thinking. Nevertheless, he was patient with them, giving them time to work on

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and shy to associate with and converse with others. On the other hand, try not to lose patience with someone who is outgoing and expressive. We cannot expect to be best friends with everyone, but we need to keep in mind that even Christians with very different personalities can work well together.

14. On what will our patience help us to focus?

14 Patience will help us to focus on the good qualities of our brothers and sisters. When we do this, we are less likely to see our different personalities as a barrier to friendship. For example, James and John selfishly desired prominence; yet, their attitude showed that the Kingdom was real to them. Jesus noticed and appreciated their faith. When we look for the good in our friends, we are imitating Jesus as well as his Father, Jehovah.

12

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WHEN OUR BROTHERS AND SISTERS ARE SUFFERING

16. What challenges may we face when our brothers and sisters are suffering in some way?

16 *Why is it a challenge?* When our brothers and sisters are suffering physically or experiencing emotional distress, they may respond in ways that we find difficult to deal with. For example, they may be withdrawn, irritable, or even unpredictable. Perhaps they will say or do things that hurt us. ([Job 6:2, 3](#)) Because we may not be aware of the challenges that our fellow believers are facing, we may expect too much of them.

17. What do you learn from the way Jesus treated the blind man Bartimaeus?

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18. How should you treat your friends who are suffering? ([1 Thessalonians 5:14](#))

18 *How can you maintain your friendships?* Be kind and compassionate. These tender qualities will help you to “speak consolingly” to your brothers and sisters who are suffering physically or emotionally. (**Read [1 Thessalonians 5:14](#).**) Remember that a true friend is ready to help, especially during “times of distress.” ([Prov. 17:17](#)) Such a friend not only sympathizes with those who are suffering but also does all he can to provide emotional support, words of encouragement, and practical help.

19. How can we demonstrate kindness and compassion? (See also pictures.)

19 What are some practical ways to show kindness and compassion?

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True friends provide comfort through compassion and kindness (See paragraph 19)

20. What kind of friend do you want to be?

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- when you disagree about a matter?

- when your personalities differ?

- when your brother or sister is suffering?

SONG 124 Ever Loyal

* **PICTURE DESCRIPTION:** An older brother and a younger brother differ in opinion about a territory matter. They later unitedly share in the ministry.

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